

F R I D A Y

CHOOSE PEACEFULNESS

EXPLORING PEACE

In a busy world, moments of quietness are very important. We need to slow down, and press 'pause', so that we have time to reflect on our lives. Our over-stimulated bodies and minds need to take a break so that they can rest and be refreshed. It is good for us to breathe deeply and slowly, to help calm our bodies. We can imagine that we are



Key Verse

My peace I give to you. John 14:27 NKJV

Cover a small box with 'peaceful' or blue paper and write 'Peace' on it. Pass it from person to person, saying the memory verse as you pass it on. Stress the words 'my peace' for the first time around the circle, then 'I give' on the second time, and 'to you' on the third time.

breathing in God's peace, and breathing out all the things that disturb our peace. Moments of peace are good for our children. They need time in their busy lives to pause and reflect and rest, not so that they can take a nap, but so that they can learn how to calm themselves down whenever they feel stressed or frightened.

When we experience a deep sense of peace with God, it helps us to face our challenges with the calm reassurance that He is in control of the situation. When we experience His peace, we are less likely to say and do things that hurt others, or cause arguments, and we are more likely to be kind and wise.

Today we will learn about the peace that Jesus brings into our lives, that helps us to stay calm in the storms of life.



PEACE IN THE STORM (MATTHEW 8)

Jesus wanted to leave a very special gift for His friends. It was to be something that everyone could enjoy, wherever they were. It was the gift of a peaceful heart. As soon as Jesus was born the angels came to tell the shepherds that God was sending a message of peace to the whole world through this little baby.

When Jesus started to preach, He saw how worried and troubled the crowds were. They were worried about their food, and their clothes, and their money and their jobs, and the tax collectors and the Roman soldiers...With all these worries filling their minds, it was difficult for them to be still and peaceful. It was hard for them to listen to Jesus, and to think about what He was saying.

One day Jesus and His disciples climbed into a boat to cross the lake of Galilee. It was a large lake with hills around it, and strong storms could blow up very quickly. Jesus was tired from a long day of preaching, teaching, and talking to people. He lay down in the bottom of the boat and fell fast asleep. Soon a wild storm crashed around the little crew. The waves splashed over the side of the boat and water started to fill the wooden hull. The boat rose and fell on the large waves. It swirled and dipped, and everyone was holding on tightly to the boat and the ropes.

The disciples were scared, even the fishermen that were used to storms. They used all their strength to keep the boat upright and afloat. They were so busy and frightened that they forgot that Jesus was in the boat, until someone remembered, and woke Him up to help them bail out the water. Jesus sat up and saw His frantic and frightened friends. They thought they were going to drown!

Jesus asked them 'Why are you so scared? I am here with you!' Then He stood up in the boat and told the winds and waves to calm down. Suddenly the lake was smooth and still as a mirror. The bright moon reflected in the water. The wind rested, and the waves barely shivered. The disciples breathed a huge sigh of relief. They sat down in the boat and all their stresses and fears were soothed by Jesus' loving care and peacefulness.

Just before Jesus left His disciples to go back to heaven, He told them not to be afraid or troubled because He was going to make a place so that everyone who loves God can live together in peace forever. We can choose to be peaceful in the storms of our lives because Jesus is always with us. His perfect love takes away all our fears, because, no matter what happens, we are always safe in His loving care.

UNFOLDING PEACE PRAYER

- Cut cloud shapes from thin paper.
- Write the word 'Peace' on one side with a ball-point pen.
- Fill a wide bowl with water.
- Use pencils to write worries on the blank side of the clouds.
- Fold the edges of the cloud over the word 'Peace'.
- Float the clouds on water with the folded edges uppermost.
- Pray for God to calm the storms in your mind and give you peace.
- Watch as the 'clouds' open and you can see 'Peace'.



EXPERIENCING PEACE ACTIVITIES

FLOURISH! - CHOOSE WELL - THINK WELL - LIVE WELL - GROW WELL!



Calm-down Kit

Make a family calm-down kit in a basket. Fill it with things that help you to feel peaceful:

- Containers of bubbles (if available).
- Lavender oil, or other soothing fragrances.
- Chamomile tea bags.
- Hand cream.
- Safe candles.
- Book of peace Bible messages, or print or write Bible texts on small pieces of paper.
- Coloring books of Bible stories with crayons or coloring pencils.



Peace Candle

- Find a clean jar with straight sides.
- Print the word 'PEACE' on a strip of paper that will wrap around the jar.
- Tape the strip around the jar.
- Place a small candle or battery-operated candle in the jar and light it.
- The word 'PEACE' will illuminate.
- When we have the light and love of Jesus in our hearts, peace will shine out of our lives to others.



Storm Bottle

Make a storm bottle by gathering the following things:

- A small plastic, lidded bottle with clear sides.
- Water.
- Blue coloring – a drop of paint, food-coloring or ink
- Clear oil.
- Boat-shaped pieces of foam, cork, or twigs.
- Pour equal amounts of oil and water into the bottle, plus the blue coloring. Add the floating shapes. Screw lid on firmly. Tell the story of Jesus calming the storm. Start with the bottle horizontal and still. When the storm comes, keep the bottle horizontal and shake it to make the storm. Then hold it still again when Jesus calms the storm.



Dove Mobile

- Make some paper doves. See www.craftow.com for more paper dove ideas.
- Write a Bible verse about peace on each side of the doves.
- Hang the doves using a thin thread, and check that the birds are well-balanced. Add more doves if you wish, to make a flock of peace!